

Russia likely to escalate hybrid warfare against NATO countries

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【メール原文】

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Daily Brief

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summary

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In the coming months, Russia is expected to escalate hybrid warfare activity against NATO countries; however, this is unlikely to trigger all-out war between Russia and the West.

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The Houthi seizure of Yemen's western coast is a significant setback for Saudi Arabia, with escalation a real possibility.

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Ian Bremmer is considerably more worried about the escalation risk in the Russia-Ukraine conflict than the US-Iran one.

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In Brazil, the Master Bank scandal is symptomatic of broader institutional degradation.

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Countries and sectors in this edition of the Daily Brief include the US, Colombia, Brazil, the EU, the Middle East and North Africa, Russia, Ukraine, geoeconomics, and oil.

the top line

EU, Russia—Hot war with the West remains unlikely as Russia escalates hybrid activity

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The coming months will see an escalation of Russian hybrid warfare activity against NATO countries, who will adopt a mainly defensive posture against these measures, strengthening their resilience and refraining from responding with hybrid counterstrikes.

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Russia's hybrid escalation is unlikely to trigger all-out war between Russia and the West (10% probability), but cannot be completely excluded, given the potential for misjudgments and accidents to spiral into retaliation and escalation.

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The US has adopted a more reassuring posture in Europe in recent months, strengthening European security through increased diplomacy, military exercises, and ramped-up support for Ukraine, but the durability of that alignment remains a key signpost.

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Read more here . Reach out to discuss: europe@eurasiagroup.net .

MENA Crisis, Oil—Conference call recap

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The Houthi seizure of Yemen's western coast is a significant setback for Saudi Arabia, with escalation a real possibility (40% odds) given Crown Prince Mohammed bin Salman's difficult negotiating position and maximalist Houthi demands.

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Saudi Arabia's East-West Pipeline, with a capacity of 3-4 million barrels per day, is currently offline, while Brent spiked to \$108 per barrel and is holding above \$100, with several additional upward price pressures in play.

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The US-Iran standoff is expected to persist through year-end, as neither side is prepared to negotiate, and the summit between Iran and the Gulf Cooperation Council in Oman on 14 September is unlikely to produce a substantive breakthrough without US concessions.

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Read more here . Reach out to discuss: mena@eurasiagroup.net .

Goeconomics, oil—Chart of the day: Gas price surge outruns oil as shipping risk tops pipeline outage

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Reach out to discuss: goeconomics@eurasiagroup.net .

US, MENA Crisis—Trump likely to avoid using US firepower in Yemen

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The Houthis' seizure of the Bab al-Mandeb Strait in Yemen poses a new problem for the White House, mostly through its effect on global oil markets.

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Saudi Arabia has few military options to reverse Houthi advances—local partners in Yemen collapsed and show little willingness to fight, and direct Saudi attacks risk leading to retaliation that could cause unacceptable collateral damage to static oil pipeline infrastructure. That means diplomatic efforts are the more likely path. It's unlikely that President Donald Trump wants to get involved in what could become another military entanglement; his efforts against the Houthis early in his term sputtered, likely reducing his willingness to have another go.

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What is more likely is US support for Saudi-led diplomatic efforts, and potential operational support, such as intelligence-sharing and the sending of additional military advisors, for Saudi military efforts that may precipitate.

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Read more here . Reach out to discuss: unitedstates@eurasiagroup.net .

EG Update—Ian Bremmer compares global conflicts

US-Iran: Having witnessed the initial consequences of unfettered escalation...neither side is willing to risk what would happen if critical infrastructure gets broadly targeted...The resulting expectation for the coming months—no conflagration in the region, but instead continued disruption of the Strait of Hormuz and Bab al-Mandeb, ongoing low level military conflict and proxy fighting, and no diplomatic breakthrough.

Russia-Ukraine: Ukraine's improved capabilities to defend itself and show that it "has the cards" in a balance of power against Russia has led the Russians to expand their efforts to defeat the Ukrainians and to directly threaten Ukraine's NATO supporters. Baseline expectations in the war over the coming year is a significant escalation—with Ukraine set to face its hardest winter and the Russians prepared to risk greater pariah status (and direct damage to itself) to allow President Vladimir Putin to "win" the war. Of the two conflicts, near to medium term there's a lot more to be worried about in Russia-Ukraine.

For more of Ian's insights on US-China ties, artificial general intelligence, and the AfD's win in Germany, read the EG Update .

Brazil—Supreme court scandal signals broader institutional degradation

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The Master Bank scandal, Brazil's largest banking fraud in history, is a headwind for President Luiz Inacio Lula da Silva's reelection (55% odds).

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The scandal is symptomatic of a larger institutional degradation on three fronts over the past ten years: (i) growing influence peddling in court decisions, particularly by law firms employing family members of superior court justices, (ii) growing co-optation of the political sphere by organized crime, and (iii) diffuse corruption among lawmakers who have appropriated an unprecedented share of budget resources, and who increasingly defend their own business interests.

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Together, these three vectors don't represent an institutional crisis, but rather a slow-moving institutional decay that undermines trust in the country's institutions and business environment.

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Read more here . Reach out to discuss: brazilresearch@eurasiagroup.net .

upcoming conference calls

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15 September 8:00 PM ET / 9:00 am SGT / 10:00 am JST / 11:00 am AEST—Taiwan elections and risk outlook. Register here .

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16 September 9:30 AM ET / 10.30 am BRT—Brazil update. Register here .

eg in depth

Colombia—CARF warning sharpens pressure for fiscal adjustment measures: In a statement published on 10 September, the Fiscal Rule Autonomous Committee (CARF) again highlighted the dire state of public finances and the need for urgent structural adjustment measures on both revenue and spending. President Abelardo de la Espriella's administration will probably seek to deliver a better result than the 9.4% of GDP fiscal deficit projected in its revised 2027 proposal through budget negotiations in congress and a forthcoming fiscal adjustment bill. Even so, fiscal repair will probably take years because room for spending cuts is limited, while aggressive revenue measures could trigger political and social backlash. Read more here . Reach out to discuss: latinamerica@eurasiagroup.net .

Upcoming events:

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15 September: Events: US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent to appear before the House Financial Services Committee for annual testimony on the international financial system; Data: China property prices, retail sales, and industrial production.

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16 September: Data: Eurozone IP, Japan trade, and UK CPI; Central bank decisions: Brazil and United States.

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17 September: Data: Eurozone CPI; Central bank decisions: UK.

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18 September: Events: NATO Military Committee Conference begins in Copenhagen, through 19 September; Data: Japan CPI, and US IP; Central bank decision: Japan.

The EG Daily Brief is compiled by Jens Larsen, Lucy Eve, Babak Minovi, Pietro Guglielmi, Rahul Bhatia, Martina Silva, Blaise Hanson, and Trista Kelley.

closing quip

"We're leading China on AI... and, frankly, I want to keep it that way because whoever wins AI, wins."—Trump said on 13 September in Ireland, downplaying risks posed by AI.

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